FIFA World Cup 2026 Predictor

Tournament forecast report · Academic analytics project · Generated 2026-06-14

Summary. A walk-forward Poisson/Dixon-Coles model estimates international A-team goal rates from a five-year rolling window of match history (recent matches upweighted; club football excluded). Match-level probabilities are validated on held-out 2018 and 2022 World Cup finals (Brier score). Because the 2026 format links group standings to a 32-team knockout bracket — including best-third-place slot assignment — tournament-stage outcomes are estimated with Monte Carlo simulation (10,000 runs). This report presents iteration 8 forecasts against the FIFA official 48-team schedule; external win-probability benchmarks appear later for comparison only.

48	0.736	0.722
TEAMS (2026 SCHEDULE)	BEST 2018 BRIER (ITER 8)	BEST 2022 BRIER (ITER 8)

PARTICIPATING NATIONS — MODEL PREDICTION ORDER

48 teams arranged by group (A–L), in model pick order: 1st, 2nd, Best 3rd, then 4th. Flags via flagcdn.com — not official FIFA branding.

Group A



1ST
South Korea



2ND
Mexico



BEST 3RD
Czechia



4TH
South Africa

Group B



1ST
Switzerland



2ND
Canada



BEST 3RD
Qatar



4TH
Bosnia and Herzegovina

Group C



1ST
Morocco



2ND
Brazil



BEST 3RD
Scotland



4TH
Haiti

Group D



1ST
Australia



2ND
USA



BEST 3RD
Turkey



4TH
Paraguay

Group E



1ST
Germany



2ND
Ivory Coast



BEST 3RD
Ecuador



4TH
Curacao

Group F



1ST
Japan



2ND
Netherlands



BEST 3RD
Tunisia



4TH
Sweden

Group G



1ST
New Zealand



2ND
Iran



BEST 3RD
Egypt



4TH
Belgium

Group H



1ST
Spain



2ND
Uruguay



BEST 3RD
Saudi Arabia



4TH
Cape Verde

Group I



1ST
France



2ND
Senegal



BEST 3RD
Norway



4TH
Iraq

Group J



1ST
Argentina



2ND
Algeria



BEST 3RD
Austria



4TH
Jordan

Group K



1ST
Portugal



2ND
Colombia



BEST 3RD
Uzbekistan



4TH
DR Congo

Group L









1ST	2ND	BEST 3RD	4TH
England	Croatia	Panama	Ghana

METHODOLOGY

- **Training data:** Kaggle martj42 international A-team results; five-year window before each cutoff; 2-year half-life decay.
- **Fixtures:** FIFA.com official 2026 schedule (local CSV), with playoff slots resolved from UEFA/FIFA results.
- **Model:** Log-linear Poisson goals with tier weights, Elo anchor, Dixon-Coles τ, opponent difficulty, and competition-context weights (iterations 3–7); optional squad-value prior blend (iteration 8 prototype).
- **Validation:** Walk-forward — tune on 2018 World Cup, confirm on 2022; 64 finals matches held out per year.
- **DataCamp:** competition submission format only (match_id, schema) — not used as fixture authority.

WHY MONTE CARLO SIMULATION?

Dixon-Coles Poisson yields **match-level** score probabilities, not tournament-stage outcomes directly. The 2026 format adds twelve groups, eight best-third-place qualifiers mapped to fixed knockout slots, and bracket dependencies that have no closed-form winner probability. We simulate many independent tournaments (10,000), sample scores from the model, apply FIFA tiebreak rules, and aggregate P(win), P(reach each stage), and group-advancement rates.

BRIER SCORE & DIXON-COLES

Brier score. For each World Cup match we predict three probabilities (home win, draw, away win). The Brier score is the mean squared error between those probabilities and the actual result (expressed as a one-hot vector). Lower is better: 0 is perfect; about **0.67** is the benchmark from naively guessing one-third for every outcome. We average over all 64 held-out tournament matches to compare iterations and years. Iteration choice for development uses the lowest 2018 Brier; 2022 is reported as confirmation without re-tuning.

Dixon-Coles. Classical Poisson models assume home and away goals are independent; real football shows extra correlation on low scores (0–0, 1–0, 0–1, 1–1), especially draws. Dixon and Coles (1997) multiply independent Poisson probabilities by a correction factor τ (rho, ρ) on those scorelines. Our pipeline learns team attack and defense rates via Poisson negative log-likelihood (iterations 1–4); **iteration 5** adds the τ term in training and when converting goal rates to win/draw/loss probabilities. World Cup match scoring

uses neutral venues (no home advantage). Elo anchoring (iter 4+) shrinks team strengths toward a stable rating so single shock results do not dominate.

BACKTEST — BRIER SCORE (LOWER IS BETTER)

Year	Iter	Brier	Model favourite	Win %	Actual winner
2018	1	1.2031	Costa Rica	25.3%	France
2018	2	0.7858	Brazil	17.1%	France
2018	3	0.7594	Brazil	18.4%	France
2018	4	0.7424	Brazil	16.9%	France
2018	5	0.7465	Brazil	16.5%	France
2018	6	0.7474	Brazil	17.9%	France
2018	7	0.7387	Brazil	15.6%	France
2018	8	0.7360	Brazil	15.0%	France
2022	1	1.0913	Portugal	14.1%	Argentina
2022	2	0.7737	Brazil	13.0%	Argentina
2022	3	0.7638	Brazil	21.3%	Argentina
2022	4	0.7363	Brazil	13.1%	Argentina
2022	5	0.7362	Brazil	12.5%	Argentina
2022	6	0.7347	Brazil	13.0%	Argentina
2022	7	0.7262	Canada	11.7%	Argentina
2022	8	0.7221	Canada	12.6%	Argentina

EXTERNAL BENCHMARK — OPTA PRE-TOURNAMENT WIN % (ITERATION 8)

Post-hoc comparison only; OPTA probabilities are not training inputs.

OPTA rank	Team	OPTA win %	Model win %	Delta
1	**Spain**	16.1%	9.4%	-6.7pp
23	**Japan**	0.8%	8.6%	+7.8pp
20	**Morocco**	0.9%	6.8%	+5.9pp
4	**Argentina**	10.4%	6.8%	-3.6pp
3	**England**	11.2%	5.8%	-5.3pp
6	**Brazil**	6.6%	5.5%	-1.1pp
2	**France**	13.0%	4.6%	-8.4pp
5	**Portugal**	7.0%	4.5%	-2.6pp
7	**Germany**	5.1%	4.0%	-1.1pp
9	**Norway**	3.5%	3.4%	-0.1pp
13	**Colombia**	1.7%	3.1%	+1.4pp
28	**South Korea**	0.5%	2.8%	+2.3pp

GROUP-STAGE OUTLOOK (12 GROUPS → ROUND OF 32)

Model picks for group winner, runner-up, and best third-place qualifier candidate. 48-team format: 24 auto-qualifiers + 8 best third-place teams.

Group	1st	2nd	Best 3rd
A	South Korea	Mexico	Czechia
B	Switzerland	Canada	Qatar
C	Morocco	Brazil	Scotland
D	Australia	USA	Turkey
E	Germany	Ivory Coast	Ecuador
F	Japan	Netherlands	Tunisia
G	New Zealand	Iran	Egypt
H	Spain	Uruguay	Saudi Arabia

Group	1st	2nd	Best 3rd
I	France	Senegal	Norway
J	Argentina	Algeria	Austria
K	Portugal	Colombia	Uzbekistan
L	England	Croatia	Panama

KNOCKOUT REACH PROBABILITIES

Monte Carlo estimates of advancing through each knockout round (iteration 8).

Team	P(QF)	P(SF)	P(Final)	P(Win)
Spain	59.8%	40.6%	16.0%	9.4%
Japan	57.8%	37.4%	14.2%	8.6%
Morocco	77.4%	44.2%	13.4%	6.8%
Argentina	53.1%	32.2%	11.6%	6.8%
England	55.1%	33.0%	10.6%	5.8%
Brazil	67.4%	37.7%	10.4%	5.5%
France	53.7%	29.6%	8.9%	4.6%
Portugal	51.0%	28.0%	8.3%	4.5%
Germany	82.2%	28.0%	8.0%	4.0%
Norway	52.4%	27.2%	6.8%	3.4%

KEY FINDINGS & LIMITATIONS

- Elo anchoring (iter 4+) limits overreaction to isolated shock results in training.
- Dixon-Coles τ (iter 5+) improves low-score and draw calibration on held-out World Cup matches.
- Iteration 8 adds Transfermarkt squad-value priors; modest Brier improvement on 2018/2022 — retained for sensitivity analysis.

- No xG or injury data; neutral venues at World Cup inference; live updates require re-running with a new cutoff.

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